

Wednesday, 5 November 2025

NEWSLETTER

PPG INDUSTRIAL TALK

Summary



On November 5th, we have attended an industrial talk by PPG provided insights into their global operations and digital infrastructure. The session focused on their extensive "SAP implementation journey," demonstrating how the company uses this powerful ERP software to manage its business. MrThong explained how SAP's modular system supports key operations, from initial procurement to final customer sales. The talk also covered PPG's long history of using SAP since 1991 and the importance of its global technology centers, including the hub in Malaysia, in supporting its ongoing digital transformation.

The Technologies and Issues

The talk highlighted how SAP acts as the backbone of PPG's global business operations. Mr Patrick shared SAP's evolution, from the early R/1 and R/2 versions to R/3, SAP ECC, and now the latest S/4HANA Cloud, which runs on the high-speed HANA in-memory database. These systems support key business processes—Procure-to-Pay (PTP), Demand-to-Replenish (DTR), Order-to-Cash (OTC), and Record-to-Report (RTR)—helping PPG maintain consistent and efficient operations across regions. He also discussed real-world challenges during ERP implementation, including the complexity of migrating from ECC to S/4HANA, integrating older systems, the time-intensive nature of the process, and ensuring users are properly trained to adapt to new workflows. Additionally, moving to the cloud brings extra considerations, such as system performance, data security, and coordination among global teams. Toward the end, Mr Patrick highlighted ten reasons why SAP is a valuable career path, emphasizing its high industry demand, strong job stability, and broad opportunities for skills development.

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This was the second time I have attended a talk from PPG, and this session helped me gain greater knowledge of how a global business operates. This time, the talk focused more on how a company like PPG uses SAP to make its operations more efficient and organized. It showed me how beneficial these technologies are in the real world. Furthermore, I also just realized that there are so many other departments or modules in the IT world, which makes me feel curious and want to learn more about other areas beyond just data analysis.

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Through this sharing, I gained a deeper insight into how PPG uses SAP ERP and how the system supports day-to-day business activities. Understanding the transition from older SAP versions to S/4HANA Cloud helped me appreciate how technology continues to enhance business performance. I also learned about the three main SAP areas—functional, technical, and reporting—which showed me that there are many directions I can explore. Overall, the session encouraged me to discover which module suits me best and to continue improving my SAP knowledge for future career growth.